

RULE OF THE GUN

The stereotype of the gun-toting criminal is changing as professionals, businessmen, students and even housewives are using arms to settle personal scores. Are lax licencing laws to be blamed for this rising culture of violence?

■ By Kimi Dangor and Renu Ojha

Urban stress and emotional vulnerability are taking a deadly new toll as life and death literally rest on a hair trigger. Last week's shocking case of 23-year-old aspiring actor Moushami Das a.k.a. Moon, whose ex-lover Avinash Bhupen Patnaik, 22, gunned down two of her family members in Mumbai before turning the pistol on himself because she had spurned him, is only the latest manifestation of the impact of gun culture in urban India. The last few months have seen a sharp spike in the number of cases where ordinary civilians have whipped out pistols or revolvers and shot at someone, usually resulting in death. In many such instances, they were triggered by road rage and seemingly minor issues.

Consider these: On November 29, 2007, a prominent builder's son Varun Malik was reportedly shot dead in Delhi's posh Vasant Kunj market by his friend Moti. Varun was shot point blank by Moti, who later claimed he was showing off his gun and it discharged accidentally. Exactly a month earlier, Mumbai hotelier Lalit D'Souza, 37, had pumped six bullets into his sister Lorna, 38. The reason for the attack was a dispute between the estranged siblings over a parking spot at their residential complex in posh Cuffe Parade. On September

11, K. Venkat, son of Andhra Pradesh Congress chief, was accused of shooting his friend and business partner, Prashant Reddy, with his licenced pistol. Another crime of passion which shook Mumbai in March this year was that of a small-time actor Deepak Malik shooting his girlfriend, actress Sanjana Srivastava, 24, in the head. Though Srivastava survived the bullet injury, she gave up her Bollywood dreams and bid good bye to Mumbai only to return to her parents' home in Lucknow.

While these cases are the more recent ones, it was the shooting of BJP leader Pramod Mahajan by his brother Pravin, that really grabbed the headlines and turned the spotlight on the increasing use of firearms to settle scores, whether personal, professional, familial or even road rage. In Das's case, it was a scorned lover who could not bear her indifference and was forced to take such a step. Patnaik, an Orissa-based entrepreneur, and Das had reportedly been together for some time before she decided to end the relationship. For days before the incident, he sent her threatening

SMSes saying, "Call back now or I will kill you". She even filed a non-cognisable complaint at the police station in Oshiwara, a hub for Bollywood aspirants in Mumbai. Little did Das know that angered by her rejection, Patnaik would travel all the way from Orissa to Mumbai,

shoot her mother and maternal uncle at her Andheri residence before turning the revolver on himself and taking his own life.

A rejected lover in this case, but pure sibling rivalry in the D'Souza affair where a brother shot at his own sister over a parking space argument. Thankfully Lorna miraculously survived to tell the tale, but these trigger-happy stories are just few instances of the growing gun menace in India's big cities, where ending a human life is no longer the domain of sharpshooters and criminals. Says social psychiatrist Dr Harish Shetty, "Metros in India are becoming melting pots in psychological terms. People are being pushed hard and global angst is short on the fuse. Hence, cases of suicide, violence, anger and rape are increasing. And there's no fear of mechanism of redress and punishment." Neuro-psychiatrist Dr Rajesh Parikh agrees, "We are looking at an increasing culture of violence, where brutality, not negotiation, is the solution. There is also an increasing de-

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